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Understanding Phishing

What is phishing?

Phishing is a cyberattack in which criminals impersonate trusted organisations or individuals to trick victims into revealing confidential information or performing unsafe actions.

Information attackers target

- Passwords and login credentials.
- Banking and payment information.
- Personal identification information.
- Business and corporate information.
- Access to organisational systems.

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Types of Phishing

Common phishing techniques

- **Email phishing:** Fraudulent emails designed to steal information.
- **Spear phishing:** Targeted attacks against specific individuals or organisations.
- **Whaling:** Attacks that specifically target senior executives.
- **Smishing:** Phishing attacks delivered through SMS messages.
- **Vishing:** Fraudulent telephone or voice-based attacks.
- **QR phishing:** Malicious QR codes that direct victims to fraudulent websites.
- **Business Email Compromise:** Fraud involving impersonated or compromised business email accounts.

How does phishing work?

An attacker sends a deceptive message that appears to come from a trusted source. The victim may be encouraged to click a link, open an attachment, transfer money or reveal sensitive information.

Real-world example

An employee receives an email that appears to come from the company's IT department. The email claims that the employee's account will be disabled unless their password is verified. The employee must recognise the warning signs and verify the request independently.

> **Key lesson:** Never trust a message simply because it looks professional. Always verify unexpected requests.

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Practical example

You receive a text message claiming that a parcel cannot be delivered until you pay a small additional fee. The message contains an unfamiliar payment link. This could be a smishing attempt.

> **Key lesson:** Phishing is not limited to email. It can happen through messages, phone calls and QR codes.

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